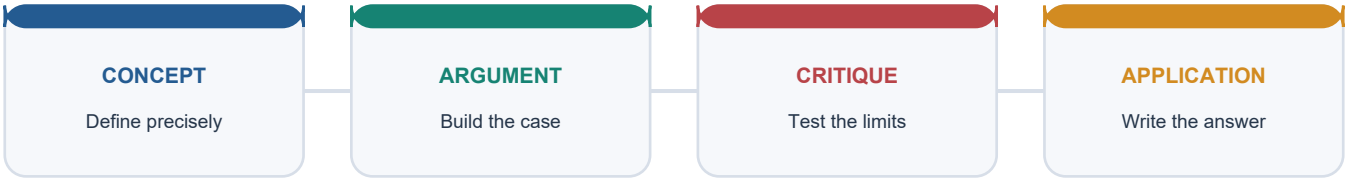
SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Mughal Society, Economy & Culture - Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC solved practice workbook | Independent MCQs, verified PYQs and Mains models | Cross-referenced with the Learning file

LEARNING PATH



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Mughal Society, Economy & Culture - Solved Practice Workbook

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

PART I - Independent solved practice

Solved MCQ set (32; keys A-B-C-D x8)

Conceptually distinct from the Learning file's 16 MCQs; no items are recycled from any prior broad or remedial bank. Correct positions rotate A -> B -> C -> D continuously. Every option carries its own explanation, and every question carries one named trap.

Q1. Mughal education is best summarised as

- A. A network of maktab/madrasa, khanqah, pathshala/math and craft apprenticeship, not one state school system
- B. A single centralised state curriculum for all subjects
- C. Education confined only to the nobility
- D. A system with no religious institutions involved

Answer: A.

Option analysis:

- A: Correct: education ran through plural, overlapping institutions (Persian/Islamic, Sanskrit/vernacular, craft) with no single state curriculum.
- B: Wrong: there was no centralised state curriculum; maktab/madrasa, pathshala/math and household learning operated in parallel, not as one system.
- C: Wrong: apprenticeship, mosque/temple learning and household transmission also reached artisans and professionals, not the nobility alone.
- D: Wrong: mosques/madrasas and temples/maths were central sites of instruction, so religious institutions were deeply involved.

Trap: Treating 'education existed' as proof of a modern, uniform, state-run schooling system.

Q2. The most accurate statement on Mughal slavery/servitude is that it

- A. Was identical in form and scale to Atlantic plantation slavery
- B. Took domestic, military, court and labour forms, and manumission did not remove the institution
- C. Had already disappeared by Akbar's reign
- D. Applied only to war captives and never to debt or birth

Answer: B.

Option analysis:

- A: Wrong: Atlantic plantation slavery is a distinct large-scale export-labour system; equating the two erases real differences in form and context.
- B: Correct: slavery/servitude existed across domestic, military, court and labour settings; manumission was praised in principle but did not abolish the institution.
- C: Wrong: sources across the period, not only pre-Akbar, register slavery/servitude; it was not a phenomenon that vanished early.
- D: Wrong: enslavement could follow war, purchase, debt or birth/trafficking - not war captivity alone.

Trap: Assuming any non-Atlantic slave system must therefore be mild or merely 'benign service'.

Q3. Raiyati/muzarian cultivators are best described as

- A. Imperial revenue-assignment holders (jagirdars)
- B. A synonym for khud-kasht resident owner-cultivators

- C. An ordinary/varied cultivator-tenant category distinct from khud-kasht and pahi-kasht
- D. Landless labourers with no cultivation rights at all

Answer: C.

Option analysis:

- A: Wrong: jagirdar is an imperial revenue-assignment category, unrelated to a cultivator's local rural status.
- B: Wrong: khud-kasht denotes a resident owner-cultivator with a stronger position; raiyati/muzarian is a separate, more varied ordinary category.
- C: Correct: raiyati/muzarian names an intermediate, varied class of ordinary cultivators/tenants, distinct from resident khud-kasht and incoming pahi-kasht.
- D: Wrong: the category still carried cultivation and occupancy-linked claims; it was not equivalent to landless labour.

Trap: Collapsing all three cultivator categories (khud-kasht/raiyati-muzarian/pahi-kasht) into one undifferentiated 'peasant'.

Q4. The zabt/dahsala assessment method is most accurately described as

- A. A flat per-village lump-sum tax unrelated to measurement
- B. A purely customary levy with no state role
- C. A one-time settlement never revised across regions
- D. A cash-demand system using measurement and multi-year price/yield averages to fix a state-share norm

Answer: D.

Option analysis:

- A: Wrong: zabt/dahsala relied on measured area and average price/yield data, not an unmeasured village lump sum.
- B: Wrong: it was a state-administered fiscal method run through officials, not a purely local custom.
- C: Wrong: assessment practice varied by region and time; it was not one unrevised, universal settlement.
- D: Correct: the method converted measured land and multi-year averages into a cash demand under a state-share norm, distinct from actual realised collection.

Trap: Treating the assessed jama figure itself as proof of how much revenue was actually collected.

Q5. In Mughal revenue records, the relationship between jama and hasil is that

- A. Jama is the paper assessment and hasil the realised collection; the two are not identical
- B. Jama and hasil are two names for the same realised income figure
- C. Hasil always exceeded jama in practice
- D. Jama was fixed by zamindars alone, without state assessment

Answer: A.

Option analysis:

- A: Correct: jama records the assessed demand while hasil records what was actually collected; remissions and shortfalls kept the two apart.
- B: Wrong: treating them as synonyms erases the assessment-versus-collection gap that historians rely on to avoid overstating revenue.
- C: Wrong: hasil was typically at or below jama, given remissions for crop failure and local resistance, not routinely above it.
- D: Wrong: jama followed state assessment procedures (such as zabt/dahsala), even though zamindars mediated collection locally.

Trap: Reading a high jama figure directly as evidence of high realised state income or rural prosperity.

Q6. Patwari, qanungo and chaudhari in the revenue system are best understood as

- A. Imperial mansabdars ranked by zat and sawar

- B. Local/intermediate officials mediating assessment and collection at village/pargana level
- C. European company agents supervising customs houses
- D. Judges in the Mughal court system

Answer: B.

Option analysis:

- A: Wrong: mansab ranked service nobility on an imperial scale; these local revenue functionaries operated at a different, sub-imperial level.
- B: Correct: they mediated measurement, record-keeping and collection locally, linking cultivators and zamindars to the wider fiscal system.
- C: Wrong: these are indigenous Mughal revenue offices, not positions created by European trading companies.
- D: Wrong: their function was fiscal/administrative record-keeping, not judicial adjudication.

Trap: Confusing local record-keeping/collection officials with either imperial rank-holders or judicial officers.

Q7. Mughal agrarian ecology is best captured by the statement that

- A. Only cash crops were grown; food-grain cultivation was marginal
- B. Irrigation was uniform across the empire, using only canals
- C. Wells, Persian wheels, tanks and canals served different regions, and food and commercial crops coexisted
- D. Cash-crop cultivation proves universal peasant prosperity

Answer: C.

Option analysis:

- A: Wrong: food grains remained central to subsistence; commercial crops supplemented but did not replace them.
- B: Wrong: irrigation technique varied by ecology - wells and Persian wheels in some tracts, tanks or canals in others - not one uniform method.
- C: Correct: differentiated irrigation technology matched regional ecology, and food crops coexisted with cotton/indigo/sugarcane cultivation for the market.
- D: Wrong: market linkage coexisted with debt, cesses and subsistence risk, so it cannot be read as proof of general prosperity.

Trap: Inferring uniform prosperity or a single irrigation technology from evidence of commercial-crop cultivation.

Q8. A qasba in the Mughal urban hierarchy is best defined as

- A. A synonym for an imperial capital city
- B. A term applying only to coastal port settlements
- C. An exclusively military cantonment
- D. A smaller production/market/pilgrimage town distinct from capitals and ports

Answer: D.

Option analysis:

- A: Wrong: imperial capitals were a distinct, larger category with court functions the qasba did not carry.
- B: Wrong: ports formed their own functional type; a qasba need not be coastal at all.
- C: Wrong: qasbas were typically civilian production, market or pilgrimage centres, not primarily military encampments.
- D: Correct: the qasba was a smaller town type performing local production, exchange or pilgrimage functions within a diverse urban hierarchy.

Trap: Treating all Mughal towns as functionally identical instead of a hierarchy of capital/port/qasba/pilgrimage types.

Q9. Regional textile specialisation under the Mughals is best illustrated by

- A. Gujarat, Coromandel and Bengal each developing distinct textile production strengths
- B. All regions producing an identical uniform product for a single national market

- C. Textile production confined only to imperial karkhanas
- D. No regional variation existing in craft output

Answer: A.

Option analysis:

- A: Correct: Gujarat, the Coromandel coast and Bengal each built distinctive textile specialisations feeding both inland and overseas trade.
- B: Wrong: regions differed in product type, quality and market orientation rather than producing one uniform output.
- C: Wrong: household, workshop, merchant-advance and karkhana forms of production coexisted; karkhanas did not monopolise output.
- D: Wrong: named regional specialisation is precisely the evidence against a claim of no variation.

Trap: Assuming a single 'Mughal textile industry' rather than differentiated regional production zones.

Q10. The merchant-advance (putting-out-type) system in craft production is best described as

- A. A method used only inside imperial karkhanas
- B. Merchants advancing capital/raw material to artisans, coordinating markets while deepening producer dependence
- C. A form of mechanised factory production
- D. A system with no market coordination role at all

Answer: B.

Option analysis:

- A: Wrong: this mechanism operated mainly in private/household production alongside, not confined within, imperial karkhanas.
- B: Correct: merchants advanced funds or materials to artisans, linking dispersed production to markets while making artisans dependent on merchant capital.
- C: Wrong: production remained hand-craft/artisanal; there was no mechanisation of the kind implied by 'factory'.
- D: Wrong: coordinating scattered artisan output with markets was precisely the mechanism's function.

Trap: Reading merchant-advance coordination as evidence of industrial-style factory organisation.

Q11. Mughal technological capacity is best assessed as

- A. Stagnant with no adoption of any new device
- B. Equivalent to an early industrial takeoff
- C. Skilled and selectively adaptive, but limited by a weak bridge between learned theory and workshop practice
- D. Uniformly advanced in every sector without exception

Answer: C.

Option analysis:

- A: Wrong: selective adoption of clocks, pumps, telescopes and mechanical devices contradicts a picture of pure stagnation.
- B: Wrong: the absence of a strong theory-workshop institutional link, plus limited mechanisation/energy organisation, blocks any 'early industrial takeoff' claim.
- C: Correct: strong artisanal skill and selective device adoption coexisted with a weak institutional bridge between scholarly theory and workshop experiment.
- D: Wrong: capacity varied by sector (irrigation, textiles, metallurgy, ships, architecture), so it was not uniformly advanced everywhere.

Trap: Forcing the evidence into either a 'stagnant civilisation' or an 'inevitable industrial takeoff' narrative.

Q12. Banjaras in the Mughal inland trade network functioned mainly as

- A. Court-appointed revenue assessors

- B. Urban brokers negotiating company contracts
- C. Coin assayers and money-changers
- D. Bulk grain/supply carriers using pack-bullock and cart networks over land routes

Answer: D.

Option analysis:

- A: Wrong: revenue assessment was the domain of officials such as qanungo/patwari, not mobile trade carriers.
- B: Wrong: urban brokerage with companies was the banian's role, a distinct function from bulk overland transport.
- C: Wrong: assaying and money-changing describe the sarraf, not the banjara.
- D: Correct: banjaras moved bulk grain and other goods overland using pack-bullock/cart caravans, sustaining both civilian markets and army supply.

Trap: Merging the banjara (bulk carrier) with the banian (broker-agent) as if they performed the same function.

Q13. A sarraf in the Mughal monetary economy chiefly performed the function of

- A. Assaying, money-changing and banking services underpinning coin circulation
- B. Commanding a provincial military contingent
- C. Serving as a hereditary local zamindar
- D. Managing an imperial karkhana workshop

Answer: A.

Option analysis:

- A: Correct: sarrafs tested coin purity, changed currency and provided banking/credit functions essential to a monetised, multi-mint economy.
- B: Wrong: military command belonged to mansabdars and their contingents, an unrelated function.
- C: Wrong: zamindari was a rural rights-holding position, not a monetary-service role.
- D: Wrong: karkhana management concerned craft production/storage, not currency assay or banking.

Trap: Confusing the sarraf's currency/banking role with an administrative, military or craft-production office.

Q14. The Ain-i-Akbari's dastur-ul-amal revenue schedules are best applied to argue that

- A. A single uniform cash rate applied identically to every crop across the empire
- B. Assessment rates were set separately for cash crops such as cotton, indigo and sugarcane and for ordinary foodgrains, reflecting crop-specific value rather than one flat schedule
- C. Only foodgrain cultivation was assessed, while cash crops escaped revenue demand entirely
- D. The schedules recorded coin content and mint purity rather than land revenue

Answer: B.

Option analysis:

- A: Wrong: dastur-ul-amal schedules fixed distinct rates by crop; they were not one uniform cash figure applied to every crop alike.
- B: Correct: the schedules set separate assessment rates for cash crops such as cotton, indigo and sugarcane against ordinary foodgrains, tracking differential crop value rather than a flat rate.
- C: Wrong: foodgrains were assessed under their own dastur rates; they were not exempt, merely rated differently from cash crops.
- D: Wrong: dastur-ul-amal is a land-revenue assessment record, not a mint/coinage register; coin purity and assay were the sarraf's and mint's concern.

Trap: Treating the dastur-ul-amal as a single flat cash-rate table rather than a crop-differentiated assessment schedule.

Q15. Virji Vohra and Abdul Ghaffur are significant chiefly as examples of

- A. European company officials based in Surat

- B. Mughal provincial governors
- C. Indian merchants commanding large-scale independent overseas trading capital and networks
- D. Sufi saints associated with regional khanqahs

Answer: C.

Option analysis:

- A: Wrong: they were Indian merchants, not employees or officials of the European trading companies.
- B: Wrong: governance of a province was a mansabdar/subahdar function, unrelated to their commercial role.
- C: Correct: both commanded substantial independent trading capital and networks, showing Indian merchant agency alongside European companies, not dependence on them.
- D: Wrong: their significance is commercial, not religious/devotional.

Trap: Assuming all seventeenth-century Indian Ocean trade capital and initiative belonged to European companies alone.

Q16. The entry of European companies into Indian Ocean trade is most accurately described as

- A. An instant assumption of monopoly and territorial control
- B. A process with no interaction with existing Indian merchant networks
- C. A purely military conquest of coastal India from the outset
- D. A gradual entry into an already-existing Asian trading system, with coercive leverage building only over time

Answer: D.

Option analysis:

- A: Wrong: early company presence was commercially negotiated and constrained by Mughal authority, not an instant monopoly.
- B: Wrong: companies operated through brokers such as banians and engaged existing merchant/banking networks rather than bypassing them.
- C: Wrong: sustained territorial-military dominance developed later and unevenly, not as the opening mode of contact.
- D: Correct: Portuguese, Dutch, English and French traders entered a functioning Asian commercial system and only gradually built coercive/territorial leverage.

Trap: Reading later colonial dominance backward into the seventeenth-century terms of company entry.

Q17. The Mughal currency system is best described as

- A. A trimetallic system (gold mohur, silver rupee, copper dam) coexisting with kind exchange and coin scarcity in places
- B. A single silver-only currency used uniformly everywhere
- C. A paper-currency system administered by the state treasury
- D. A barter-only economy with no coinage at all

Answer: A.

Option analysis:

- A: Correct: gold mohur, silver rupee and copper dam circulated together, while barter/kind exchange and regional coin shortages also persisted.
- B: Wrong: gold and copper denominations existed alongside silver; it was not a single-metal system.
- C: Wrong: there was no state paper-currency system; hundis were private credit instruments, not government paper money.
- D: Wrong: coinage was extensive and central to revenue/trade, even though kind exchange also persisted in places.

Trap: Assuming a fully monetised, single-metal cash economy with no regional coin scarcity or barter.

Q18. The inflow of overseas bullion into the Mughal economy should be read as

- A. Direct, automatic evidence of rising welfare for ordinary cultivators
- B. A factor feeding currency circulation and court/urban demand, without itself proving general welfare gains
- C. Evidence that overseas trade had no monetary effect at all
- D. Proof that the state abolished land-revenue taxation because of bullion income

Answer: B.

Option analysis:

- A: Wrong: bullion inflow benefited currency circulation and elite/urban demand, but cannot be equated with improved welfare for the general cultivating population.
- B: Correct: bullion fed silver-currency circulation and court/urban consumption, but its benefits were unevenly distributed and it did not by itself raise general welfare.
- C: Wrong: bullion inflow clearly affected currency supply and market circulation; it was not monetarily inert.
- D: Wrong: land revenue remained the fiscal backbone of the state regardless of bullion inflows.

Trap: Converting evidence of bullion/trade volume directly into a claim about ordinary people's welfare.

Q19. Caste/jati in Mughal social structure is most accurately treated as

- A. Irrelevant to occupation or status
- B. A category invented only under British rule
- C. One of several axes (with rank, religion, gender, locality, slavery) shaping status and access
- D. The sole determinant of a person's entire social position

Answer: C.

Option analysis:

- A: Wrong: caste/jati visibly shaped occupation, marriage and status in the period's evidence.
- B: Wrong: caste/jati as a social category predates British rule; colonial administration reshaped rather than invented it.
- C: Correct: caste/jati worked alongside rank, lineage, religion, gender, locality and slavery/servitude as one of several intersecting axes of status.
- D: Wrong: treating caste as the sole determinant erases the role of rank, patronage, locality and gender shown in the evidence.

Trap: Reducing a multi-axis hierarchy (rank/caste/religion/gender/locality/slavery) to a single caste-only explanation.

Q20. Evidence on women's property and inheritance rights under the Mughals shows that

- A. All women held identical rights regardless of class, religion or region
- B. Property rights existed only for court women, with no ordinary-women evidence at all
- C. Legal norms guaranteed full equality with men in practice
- D. Rights and access existed but were unevenly realised across class, caste, religion and region

Answer: D.

Option analysis:

- A: Wrong: rights and their exercise varied significantly by class, caste, religion and regional custom, not uniformly.
- B: Wrong: labouring and cultivating women also appear in the record (agricultural, craft and construction work), even if elite women are more visible in court sources.
- C: Wrong: formal entitlements coexisted with unequal practical access, so 'full equality in practice' overstates the evidence.
- D: Correct: property/inheritance entitlements existed in principle, but access and enforcement varied by social position, keeping visibility distinct from equality.

Trap: Using elite women's documented property/patronage cases to infer general gender equality.

Q21. The Sufi khanqah's role in Mughal religious-cultural life is best described as a

- A. Site of devotional teaching, hospitality and local religious authority that also fed literary/historical sources such as malfuzat
- B. Purely administrative revenue office
- C. Military garrison post
- D. Location with no connection to any textual production

Answer: A.

Option analysis:

- A: Correct: khanqahs combined devotional practice, teaching and hospitality, and their circles produced malfuzat texts used as historical evidence.
- B: Wrong: revenue administration ran through separate fiscal officials, not through the khanqah's devotional/teaching functions.
- C: Wrong: khanqahs were religious-social institutions, not military installations.
- D: Wrong: malfuzat (recorded sayings/conversations) are a direct textual product connected to khanqah circles.

Trap: Treating Sufi institutions as purely spiritual with no documentary/historical-source significance.

Q22. The most careful description of Mughal religious-cultural interaction is that it

- A. Produced one single blended religion replacing all previous traditions
- B. Involved institutional dialogue and coexistence between traditions, without erasing hierarchy or doctrinal distinctness
- C. Was entirely absent; traditions never interacted
- D. Proves that caste and gender inequality had ended

Answer: B.

Option analysis:

- A: Wrong: distinct religious traditions and doctrinal identities persisted; there was no single replacement religion.
- B: Correct: translation projects, shared patronage and artistic exchange show real interaction and coexistence, while social hierarchy and doctrinal boundaries remained intact.
- C: Wrong: documented translation, patronage and artistic exchange are direct evidence of interaction, not absence of contact.
- D: Wrong: cultural interaction does not by itself demonstrate the end of caste or gender-based inequality.

Trap: Using the vague word 'syncretism' to imply that hierarchy and doctrinal difference were dissolved.

Q23. Akbar's Maktab Khana is most precisely associated with

- A. Coining new currency denominations
- B. Regional revenue settlement
- C. Sponsoring Sanskrit-Persian translation projects, including the Razmnama (Mahabharata)
- D. Organising the imperial army's cavalry contingents

Answer: C.

Option analysis:

- A: Wrong: currency issuance was a separate mint/treasury function, unconnected to the Maktab Khana's translation work.
- B: Wrong: revenue settlement (such as zabt/dahsala) was an independent fiscal process.
- C: Correct: the Maktab Khana organised translation projects such as the Razmnama and a Ramayana project, linking Sanskrit and Persian intellectual worlds.
- D: Wrong: military organisation belonged to the mansab/army system, not the translation bureau.

Trap: Confusing the Maktab Khana's translation-bureau role with unrelated fiscal or military institutions.

Q24. Careful use of the 2022-type PYQ evidence requires distinguishing that

- A. Both the Yogavasistha and the Majma-ul-Bahrain were translated by the same person in the same reign
- B. Dara Shukoh translated the Yogavasistha into Persian
- C. Nizamuddin Panipati worked during Aurangzeb's reign
- D. Nizamuddin Panipati's Persian Yogavasistha belongs to Akbar's reign, while Dara Shukoh is separately linked to Majma-ul-Bahrain/Sirr-i-Akbar

Answer: D.

Option analysis:

- A: Wrong: these are two distinct translation projects by two different scholars/princes in different reigns; conflating them is the classic error.
- B: Wrong: Nizamuddin Panipati, not Dara Shukoh, is linked to the Persian Yogavasistha/Jug Basis.
- C: Wrong: Nizamuddin Panipati's Yogavasistha translation is placed in Akbar's reign, not Aurangzeb's.
- D: Correct: keeping Nizamuddin Panipati/Yogavasistha (Akbar) separate from Dara Shukoh/Majma-ul-Bahrain and Sirr-i-Akbar is the precise, exam-safe distinction.

Trap: Merging two separately-dated, separately-authored translation projects under one generic 'Mughal translation' label.

Q25. The stylistic trajectory of Mughal painting is best summarised as moving from

- A. Akbar's workshop energy, to Jahangir's naturalism, to Shah Jahan's greater formality
- B. Shah Jahan's naturalism back to Akbar's formal court style
- C. A static style unchanged across all reigns
- D. Jahangir's formality to Akbar's naturalism

Answer: A.

Option analysis:

- A: Correct: the commonly evidenced sequence runs from Akbar's energetic atelier work, through Jahangir's naturalistic observation, to Shah Jahan's more formal courtly idiom.
- B: Wrong: this reverses the actual chronological and stylistic sequence.
- C: Wrong: workshop style visibly changed across reigns, contradicting a 'static/unchanged' claim.
- D: Wrong: naturalism is associated with Jahangir, not Akbar's earlier atelier phase, so this pairing is reversed.

Trap: Reversing or scrambling the Akbar-Jahangir-Shah Jahan stylistic sequence.

Q26. After the height of imperial patronage declined, Mughal-trained painters most notably

- A. Disappeared entirely from the historical record
- B. Dispersed into Rajasthan and Pahari courts, transforming regional painting schools
- C. Were absorbed exclusively into European company employment
- D. Continued working only inside the imperial karkhana with no external influence

Answer: B.

Option analysis:

- A: Wrong: painters did not vanish; their movement into regional courts is itself well evidenced.
- B: Correct: artists moved into Rajasthan and Pahari courts, carrying Mughal techniques into regional painting traditions.
- C: Wrong: regional Indian courts, not primarily European companies, were the main destination for dispersing painters.
- D: Wrong: dispersal into new patron courts is precisely evidence against continued isolation inside one workshop.

Trap: Assuming reduced imperial patronage meant the end of the artistic tradition rather than its regional transformation.

Q27. The correct reading of music under Aurangzeb's reign is that

- A. All music across India ceased under his rule
- B. Court musical patronage expanded to unprecedented levels
- C. Court singers faced restriction/ban, but music continued through regional and devotional patronage
- D. Music had no religious or devotional dimension anywhere in Mughal India

Answer: C.

Option analysis:

- A: Wrong: a claim of total cessation ignores continuing regional and devotional musical practice outside the restricted court context.
- B: Wrong: the evidence points to restriction of court singers, not an expansion of court musical patronage under Aurangzeb.
- C: Correct: while court singers were restricted, music persisted through regional courts and devotional/religious patronage traditions.
- D: Wrong: devotional traditions (bhakti/Sufi) show music had significant religious dimensions across the period.

Trap: Generalising a court-specific restriction under one ruler into a claim about all music everywhere.

Q28. The architectural sequence from Humayun's Tomb to the Taj Mahal illustrates

- A. No stylistic development across the dynasty
- B. A shift away from symmetry and materials such as marble and inlay
- C. Architecture produced by a single individual designer throughout
- D. A progression through Akbar/Fatehpur and Itimad-ud-Daulah toward greater marble use, inlay and symmetry, with collective craftsmanship

Answer: D.

Option analysis:

- A: Wrong: the named sequence itself (Humayun's Tomb to Fatehpur to Itimad to Taj/Red Fort/Jama Masjid) shows clear stylistic development.
- B: Wrong: later Mughal architecture moved toward more, not less, marble use, inlay work and symmetrical planning.
- C: Wrong: these monuments were collective productions of architects, craftsmen and artisans, not the output of one designer.
- D: Correct: the line of monuments shows a traceable progression toward refined marble work, inlay and symmetry, achieved through collective craftsmanship.

Trap: Crediting a single 'genius architect' rather than recognising collective, evolving craft production.

Q29. The limiting factor most often cited for Mughal scientific/technical advance is

- A. A weak institutional bridge connecting learned theoretical knowledge to workshop-level experimentation
- B. A complete absence of any scientific or technical activity
- C. Total isolation from all outside technical contact
- D. Excessive state investment in research institutions

Answer: A.

Option analysis:

- A: Correct: skilled artisanal practice and learned traditions existed in parallel, but without a strong institutional link translating theory into sustained experimental workshops.
- B: Wrong: irrigation, textile, metallurgical and architectural capacity are all evidence against a claim of no scientific/technical activity at all.
- C: Wrong: selective adoption of devices such as clocks and telescopes shows some outside technical contact, not total isolation.

- D: Wrong: the limitation identified is a weak institutional bridge, not overinvestment in research institutions (which barely existed in this sense).

Trap: Assuming skilled craftsmanship by itself proves an institutionalised science-workshop pipeline existed.

Q30. A key limitation of court chronicles and memoirs as sources for Mughal society is that they

- A. Are completely fabricated and contain no usable evidence
- B. Centre privileged, court-adjacent observers and often under-represent peasants, ordinary women and non-court regions
- C. Give a perfectly representative account of every social group
- D. Were written only after the dynasty's end, with no contemporary value

Answer: B.

Option analysis:

- A: Wrong: chronicles/memoirs contain genuine, usable evidence; the issue is representativeness, not total fabrication.
- B: Correct: their vantage point privileges court, administrative and elite perspectives, leaving peasants, many women and non-court regions less visible.
- C: Wrong: precisely because of this vantage-point bias, they cannot be read as a perfectly representative social record.
- D: Wrong: many chronicles/memoirs (such as the Akbarnama or Tuzuk-i-Jahangiri) were composed contemporaneously with the reigns they describe.

Trap: Treating silence in elite chronicles as proof of absence of the groups they under-record.

Q31. Regarding percentage-style claims in Mughal history (such as noble composition statistics), the safest approach is to

- A. Accept any percentage figure without checking date or denominator
- B. Reject all quantitative evidence as unusable
- C. Check the exact date range and denominator before generalising a percentage claim across the whole period
- D. Assume every percentage applies uniformly to the entire empire and all reigns

Answer: C.

Option analysis:

- A: Wrong: accepting figures uncritically risks misapplying a time-bound statistic (for example, a late-Aurangzeb figure) to the whole Mughal period.
- B: Wrong: dated, denominator-specific quantitative evidence (such as noble-composition data) is valuable when its scope is respected.
- C: Correct: verifying the exact date range and denominator (for example, '1679-1707, 1000-zat-and-above nobles') prevents overgeneralising a specific statistic.
- D: Wrong: statistics tied to a specific reign/rank threshold cannot be assumed to hold uniformly across the whole empire and period.

Trap: Extending a precisely dated, narrowly defined statistic into an unqualified claim about 'the Mughals' in general.

Q32. The most defensible overall verdict on Mughal society, economy and culture is that it was

- A. A uniform golden age of universal prosperity
- B. A stagnant, unchanging order until British arrival
- C. A society with no meaningful economic or cultural activity
- D. Dynamic, integrated and productive, yet hierarchical, extractive and regionally uneven

Answer: D.

Option analysis:

- A: Wrong: hierarchy, extraction and regional unevenness in the evidence rule out a simple 'golden age' description.
- B: Wrong: expansion, monetisation, craft specialisation and cultural production show change and dynamism, not stagnation.
- C: Wrong: extensive evidence of trade, craft, revenue systems and cultural institutions contradicts any claim of negligible activity.
- D: Correct: the evidence supports a graded verdict - dynamic, integrated and productive, but also hierarchical, extractive and unevenly distributed across regions and groups.

Trap: Collapsing a nuanced, evidence-graded verdict into either a 'golden age' or a 'stagnant despotism' extreme.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

PART II - Exact PYQs and direct routes

Exact routed UPSC PYQs: wording, option order and answer status

2018 Prelims GS-I Q73

Which one of the following foreign travellers elaborately discussed about diamonds and diamond mines of India?

A. Francois Bernier B. Jean-Baptiste Tavernier C. Jean de Thevenot D. Abbe Barthelemy Carre

INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED: B. Jean-Baptiste Tavernier (high confidence). A local official key is not held. Tavernier was a French jeweller-merchant whose account is specialised in diamonds/mines. Bernier is the property debate traveller; Thevenot and Carre are not the specialised diamond source. Original option order retained.

2019 Prelims GS-I Q1

With reference to Mughal India, what is/are the difference/differences between Jagirdar and Zamindar?

1. Jagirdars were holders of land assignments in lieu of judicial and police duties, whereas Zamindars were holders of revenue rights without obligation to perform any duty other than revenue collection.
2. Land assignments to Jagirdars were hereditary and revenue rights of Zamindars were not hereditary.

Select the correct answer using the code given below:

A. 1 only B. 2 only C. Both 1 and 2 D. Neither 1 nor 2

INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED: D. Neither 1 nor 2 (high confidence). Jagirdari was a transferable revenue assignment, not hereditary land assignment in the asserted contrast. Zamindars could have hereditary rights and were not limited to bare collection. Original option order retained.

2020 Prelims GS-I Q21

With reference to the history of India, consider the following pairs:

1. Aurang : In-charge of treasury of the State
2. Banian : Indian agent of the East India Company
3. Mirasidar : Designated revenue payer to the State

Which of the pairs given above is/are correctly matched?

A. 1 and 2 only B. 2 and 3 only C. 3 only D. 1, 2 and 3

INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED: B. 2 and 3 only (high confidence). Aurang is warehouse/depot, so Pair 1 fails. Banian fits company agent/broker and Mirasidar the exam's revenue-payer frame. Original option order retained.

2022 Prelims GS-I Q94

"Yogavasistha" was translated into Persian by Nizamuddin Panipati during the reign of:

A. Akbar B. Humayun C. Shahjahan D. Aurangzeb

INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED: A. Akbar (high confidence). Nizamuddin Panipati's Persian Yogavasistha/Jug Basis belongs to Akbar's reign. Dara Shukoh's Majma-ul-Bahrain and Sirr-i-Akbar are distinct. Original option order retained.

2020 GS-I Q12

Persian literary sources of medieval India reflect the spirit of the age. Comment. (250 words, 15 marks)

The direct ~250-word examiner-grade answer appears as Mains 1 below. It treats "reflect" as qualified "refract," uses named genres and evidence, and ends with corroboration.

PART III - Original Mains practice with model solutions

Seven examiner-grade solved Mains questions

One PYQ-tied answer plus six original Mains answers (2 x 10, 2 x 15, 2 x 20 marks). Each answer follows claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification -> verdict.

Mains 1. 2020 GS-I Q12 (15 marks, 250 words): Persian literary sources of medieval India reflect the spirit of the age. Comment.

Model solution

Persian literary sources are indispensable to medieval India, but "reflect" requires qualification. Court chronicles such as Barani's Tarikh-i-Firuz Shahi and Abul Fazl's Akbarnama disclose ideas of sovereignty, hierarchy and legitimate rule; Ain-i-Akbari turns revenue categories, offices and courtly order into an imperial knowledge project. Memoirs such as Baburnama and Tuzuk-i-Jahangiri offer more personal registers, while Sufi malfuzat such as Fawaid-ul-Fuad reveal devotional language and urban religious worlds. Translation projects such as Razmnama show scholarly contact across Sanskrit and Persian fields.

These sources reveal political vocabulary, literary aesthetics, patronage, religious debate and administrative aspiration. Badauni's dissenting tone itself prevents their reduction to unbroken official praise. Yet genre is a limit: chronicles seek legitimacy, compendia classify for rule, and memoirs centre privileged observers. Peasants, many women, oral communities and non-court regions remain unevenly visible; silence is not absence.

Persian letters, biographies and regional chronicles further register networks of service, learning and memory that a single imperial chronicle cannot exhaust. They also remind us that Persian was a working language of administration and literary exchange, not merely a royal ornament. Their evidence must still be located in patronage and circulation before it is made representative.

Persian literary sources therefore refract rather than mechanically mirror the spirit of the age. A reliable reconstruction reads them with vernacular literature, inscriptions, coins, paintings, buildings, archaeology and travellers. Their partiality is historically productive because it identifies the priorities and exclusions through which medieval power represented itself.

Why this earns marks: It directly answers the directive, uses named genres/texts, explains reach and silence, and ends with corroboration.

Demand decoding: "Reflect" is the trap word in the 2020 wording; the demand is to state that Persian sources *refract* the age through genre, patronage and audience, then prove it by naming at least one chronicle, one memoir, one normative text and one Sufi malfuzat, closing with a named non-Persian corroborating evidence type.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The answer earns full marks by naming four distinct genres (chronicle, memoir, normative text, malfuzat) rather than treating "Persian sources" as one undifferentiated block, and by using Badauni's dissent as internal proof against a single-voice reading.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Open with the reflect-versus-refract correction in the first two lines; give one named example per genre (Barani/Abul Fazl, Baburnama/Tuzuk, Ain-i-Akbari, Fawaid-ul-Fuad); state what each can and cannot prove; close by naming vernacular texts, coins, inscriptions and travellers as the required corroboration set.

How to improve this answer: Add one dated named example of a corroborating non-Persian source (for instance, a regional inscription or a named traveller account) to make the closing corroboration line verifiable rather than a general instruction.

Mains 2. Discuss social hierarchy and mobility in Mughal India. (15 marks, 250 words)

Model solution

Mughal society was layered, not frozen. Emperor and household, mansabdars, local chiefs/zamindars, merchants, professionals, artisans, cultivators and labourers held different claims on office, income and status. Mansab made service rank legible, yet khanazad advantage shows social reproduction despite formal non-heredity. The dated 1679-1707 evidence that foreign-born nobles were under 10 percent of 1000-zat-and-above total corrects Bernier's foreigner generalisation without erasing ancestry prestige.

Local power complicates a court-only account. Zamindars combined revenue claims, clan/caste links, armed following and local information; their scale ranged from village gentry to rajas. Mobility came through service, military employment, trade, migration and settlement. Raja Man Singh's rise to a leading Amber-linked mansab shows upward mobility through recruitment; Pahi cultivators could enter new land on concession; Virji Vohra's Surat network shows commercial mobility. Downward movement existed too: displaced or dispossessed lineages and localised revolts, such as Gokula's 1669 Jat uprising and the 1672 Satnami revolt, show that exclusion from these channels could produce resistance rather than assured advancement. Caste, gender, access to cattle/credit and patronage constrained outcomes throughout. Gulbadan or Jahanara illuminate elite female agency, not general equality.

The correct verdict is hierarchy with channelled, two-directional movement, not either a rigid caste prison or an open, equal-opportunity ladder.

Why this earns marks: It defines structure, gives mansab/zamindar/pahi/merchant evidence and distinguishes mobility from equality.

Demand decoding: "Discuss" here demands both a structural map of who held rank, land and wealth, and a distinct discussion of the channels - service, trade, migration - through which individuals moved between those positions, closing with a verdict that separates mobility from equality.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The answer's strongest feature is the dated 1679-1707 foreign-born-noble statistic (under 10 percent of 1000-zat-and-above ranks), which directly rebuts Bernier's foreigner claim with a quantified, sourced fact rather than a general denial.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Lead with the mansab/khanazad tension (rank is non-hereditary in form, reproduced in practice); follow with the zamindar-scale evidence; use Virji Vohra for commercial mobility and Gulbadan/Jahanara for bounded elite female agency; close with the hierarchy-with-channelled-movement verdict.

How to improve this answer: Add one further named case of downward mobility or loss of status (for example, a displaced zamindar lineage) to balance the upward-mobility examples already used.

Mains 3. Examine the agrarian structure of Mughal India. (20 marks, 250 words)

Model solution

Mughal agrarian structure combined productive expansion with differentiated rights and fiscal pressure. Khud-kasht were resident owner-cultivators with stronger resource position; raiyati/muzarian categories covered varied owners and tenants; pahi-kasht entered new or abandoned land, often on concession. These are local social categories, not a uniform all-India caste schedule.

Rights were layered: cultivators held labour/occupancy claims, zamindars revenue and social claims, and the state assessment. Patil, muqaddam, chaudhuri, qanungo, patwari and deshmukh mediated with regional variation, recording, verifying and adjusting demand against local conditions rather than applying one fixed all-India schedule. Clearance, migration and resettlement extended cultivation; pattas, seed and cattle could enable it, while debt could bind it. Wells, Persian wheels, tanks and canals served different ecological settings, and Ali Mardan Khan's Punjab canal-building shows investment concentrated where court or cash-crop demand justified the cost.

Cash demand and cotton, indigo, sugarcane and oilseeds connected some regions to markets, but food crops and kind exchange remained important elsewhere. Bernier observed extraction and argued that transferable, non-hereditary jagirs removed any incentive to improve the land; this claim is qualified rather than confirmed by the layered-rights and expansion evidence above, which shows continued investment and settlement alongside insecurity. Thus the order was productive and commercially integrated but negotiated, unequal and insecure at once.

Why this earns marks: It connects categories, rights, ecology, market and source debate instead of reciting revenue formulae.

Demand decoding: "Examine" at 20 marks requires the full agrarian chain in one answer - cultivator categories, layered rights, local intermediaries, ecology/irrigation and commercial crops - plus a named historiographical test (Bernier) rather than a bare description of any single element.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The answer's strongest move is refusing to flatten khud-kasht/raiyati/pahi-kasht into "the peasantry", instead tying each category to a specific rights-bundle and then testing Bernier's transferable-jagir thesis against that layered evidence.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Open with the three cultivator categories and their rights; add the mediating officials (patwari/qanungo/muqaddam); state the crop/irrigation evidence (Persian wheels, tanks, cash crops); close by weighing Bernier's claim against the expansion evidence for a graded, non-romanticised verdict.

How to improve this answer: Name one specific irrigation technology and one specific commercial-crop region together (for example, Persian-wheel-irrigated wheat tracts versus indigo/cotton belts) to sharpen the ecology-market link beyond a general list.

Mains 4. Analyse zamindars in the Mughal rural order. (10 marks, 150 words)

Model solution

Zamindars were local power-holders rather than mere collectors. The term covered a range from village-linked claimants to chiefs and rajas, often with armed retainers, garhis, caste-clan ties and local knowledge. Zamindari rights could be hereditary, divisible and saleable, and joined revenue share to prestige.

The state needed these actors for collection, order and cultivation but also tried to regulate dues and incorporate chiefs into the mansab hierarchy. This created cooperation, mansab links and, where dues were pressed too hard, armed resistance. A zamindar could assist pahi settlement and improvement while also making exactions on the same cultivators, so the relationship carried both a stabilising and an extractive edge.

They were therefore both bridge and constraint between centre and countryside: enabling revenue flow and rural order while retaining independent armed power. Scale is the required qualification: a small rural holder cannot be equated with an autonomous raja commanding a substantial following.

Why this earns marks: It defines, gives mechanisms and ends with regional/scale qualification appropriate to ten marks.

Demand decoding: At 10 marks, "analyse" wants a compact double-sided treatment - zamindars as both collection/order-enabling collaborators and as armed, semi-autonomous local powers - not a one-sided description of either function alone.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The answer's decisive line is the closing scale caveat (a small rural holder is not equivalent to an autonomous raja), which prevents the entire answer from collapsing into a single "zamindars were powerful" generalisation.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: In three short paragraphs: define the term across its village-to-raja range; state the cooperation/resistance mechanism with one named element (garhis, mansab links); close with the bridge-and-constraint verdict plus the scale qualification.

How to improve this answer: Add one line naming a specific revenue-era term (jagirdar-versus-zamindar contrast) to sharpen the definitional boundary the 10-mark word limit otherwise compresses too quickly.

Mains 5. Discuss literature and translation as cultural interaction under the Mughals. (15 marks, 250 words)

Model solution

Cultural interaction was institutional and linguistic, not a simple fusion. Persian was imperial language of administration and high literature, while Akbar's Maktab Khana sponsored Sanskrit-Persian dialogue through Razmnama and Ramayana projects. Precision is decisive: Nizamuddin Panipati's Persian Yogavasistha/Jug Basis belongs to Akbar, whereas Dara Shukoh's secure associations are Majma-ul-Bahrain and Sirr-i-Akbar.

Vernacular production widened cultural fields well beyond the court. Tulsidas, Surdas, Rahim, Raskhan and Keshavdas gave Awadhi/Braj literary voice; Eknath, Tukaram and Ramdas carried a parallel Marathi bhakti tradition;

Sikh Guru traditions and the Adi Granth show a distinct scriptural-literary strand. Persian and regional languages coexisted and cross-fertilised, each serving different patrons, audiences and purposes, rather than one displacing the other.

Translation and literature together reveal elite intellectual dialogue, active vernacularisation and plural, overlapping cultural publics operating side by side. They do not by themselves prove that caste hierarchy, gender inequality, religious orthodoxy or political coercion vanished; orthodox objection to translated or heterodox texts is recorded precisely because such projects remained contested, not universally welcomed.

Why this earns marks: It uses exact correction, named texts/authors and distinguishes coexistence from equality.

Demand decoding: "Discuss" requires naming an actual translation project (not "translation" in the abstract) and correctly dating it to its reign, then adding a vernacular example, before drawing any conclusion about cultural interaction.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The answer's essential safeguard is the Nizamuddin Panipati/Akbar versus Dara Shukoh/Majma-ul-Bahrain-Sirr-i-Akbar correction - the exact 2022 Prelims trap - which stops the answer from conflating two separate, differently-dated intellectual projects.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: State the Maktab Khana/Razmnama mechanism first; immediately apply the Akbar-versus-Dara-Shukoh correction; add one vernacular strand (Tulsidas/Tukaram/Adi Granth) for breadth; close by separating "coexistence" from "equality" as the graded verdict.

How to improve this answer: Add one named example of orthodox resistance to translation or vernacular growth (rather than only listing the vernacular successes) to make the "did not erase difference" qualification concrete.

Mains 6. "Composite culture was real, but not socially egalitarian." Discuss. (10 marks, 150 words)

Model solution

Composite culture is observable through collaborative workshops, translation, architecture, painting, music and regional patronage. Maktab Khana translations of Sanskrit epics, Akbar's painting workshop blending Persian and Indian idioms, and artist movement into Rajasthan/Pahari courts show concrete mechanisms of interaction rather than vague harmony. Persian and vernacular literary fields coexisted and drew on each other for form and audience.

But cultural contact did not equal an equal distribution of power. Caste hierarchy, gendered restrictions, elite patronage, orthodoxy and coercion persisted alongside this exchange. Translation and painting remained largely elite pursuits; court art represented sovereignty and hierarchy as much as synthesis; elite women's visible cultural agency did not establish ordinary women's autonomy.

The verdict is relational, not egalitarian: cultural forms were made through genuine contact and adaptation, but inside an unequal social order that the contact itself left substantially intact.

Why this earns marks: It defines the claim through concrete institutions, then separates interaction from equality.

Demand decoding: At 10 marks, "discuss" the quoted claim wants the two halves treated in strict sequence - first the mechanisms proving "real" interaction, then the specific evidence proving "not egalitarian" - never blended into one vague synthesis paragraph.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The answer's strength is naming the mechanism (Maktab Khana, painting workshop, artist dispersal to Rajasthan/Pahari courts) before naming the limiting evidence (caste, gender, orthodoxy), which mirrors the quoted claim's own two-part structure.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: First sentence states the claim is accepted; next two sentences give the interaction mechanisms; final two sentences give the inequality evidence; close with the "relational, not equal" verdict in one line.

How to improve this answer: Add one named counter-example of resistance to composite practice (for instance, an orthodox objection recorded in a chronicle) to make the "not egalitarian" half as evidence-specific as the "real" half.

Mains 7. Assess the Mughal economy: prosperity, integration and limits. (20 marks, 250 words)

Model solution

The Mughal economy combined agrarian productivity, commercial integration and cultural consumption, but gains were uneven and technical transition incomplete. Silver currency, revenue demand, roads, sarais, rivers, hundis and

merchant networks linked many regions. Textiles, indigo, sugar, saltpetre and foodstuffs moved through Surat, Hugli and Masulipatnam; Virji Vohra and Abdul Ghaffur show merchant agency.

Expansion used forest clearance, pahi settlement and investment in cattle, seed and water, while khud-kasht, raiyati/muzarian, pahi, service and labour groups held sharply unequal resources and status. Zamindars mediated revenue collection and local power, joining centre and countryside; credit dependence and cess demands could turn seasonal growth into recurring insecurity for smaller cultivators. Bullion inflow, silver-currency circulation and court demand supported specific sectors and cities but cannot be read as evidence of universal welfare.

Craft skill coexisted with selective, sector-specific technology adoption - clocks, pumps, telescopes and Persian-wheel irrigation were absorbed where useful, without a matching institutional bridge from workshop skill to sustained theoretical or mechanised advance. The best judgement is dynamic, integrated and genuinely productive within a hierarchical agrarian order - neither a golden-age of shared abundance nor a stagnant, isolated economy.

Why this earns marks: It synthesises agriculture, trade, finance, class and technology with named evidence and a graded verdict.

Demand decoding: "Assess" at 20 marks demands a genuine synthesis across all four demand-family banks (agrarian, trade, society, technology) with an explicit weighing of "prosperity" against "limits" in the same paragraph, not four separate mini-essays placed side by side.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The answer's synthesis works because each sector's evidence (silver currency, named ports, named merchants, cultivator categories, craft skill) is immediately paired with its own limiting qualification, so "dynamic but hierarchical" is earned sector-by-sector rather than asserted once at the end.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Sequence agrarian expansion, then trade/finance (ports, hundi, named merchants), then social stratification, then technology, pairing each with its qualification; close with the single "dynamic, integrated, hierarchical" verdict line.

How to improve this answer: Add one explicit cross-sector link (for example, how bullion inflow from overseas trade fed silver-currency circulation that in turn financed revenue collection) to make the "integration" claim causally explicit rather than a listed juxtaposition.